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Dire Straits

1909 did not begin well for the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company.

The *Gallia* was laid up in Colombo and the *Lawoe*, which had been sailing intermittently on the coast, also began to give the *Gallia* company. If boilers were the trouble spot for the *Gallia*, the *Lawoe*'s was the want of working capital.[1]

According to the *Daily Index and Weekly Index to Lloyd's List, 1907–1911*, the *Lawoe* was grounded from late 1908, and made only twenty-two voyages between April and August 1908 with no entries at all for 1909 (Table 4.3). A British port officer recalled, more than a decade later, that it was a 'passenger ship, with worn-out boilers and hull'.[2] Once again, without nautical expertise, we cannot judge if this was a factual assessment or prejudiced opinion.

The situation was such that a section of the directors once again broached the idea of selling the ships and the company to BI. But it appears that efforts to sell the company's steamers to BI had fallen through after the latter had finally turned down the Swadeshi overtures in mid-January.[3] The details are hazy. Clearly, there was a division in the company itself: some directors did not want to give up, considering the unflagging efforts of S.D. Krishna Aiyangar and K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar to keep the company afloat. Instead, efforts were directed towards making the two steamers seaworthy and employing them for coastal trade with an occasional voyage to Colombo. Boilers for the *Gallia* had been ordered from abroad—likely from J. Mackintosh and Company—and may have reached Bombay. The outcome of these efforts, the district superintendent of police remarked, would be known by the end of February.[4]

India's Tuticorin correspondent, though conceding that the two steamers had not sailed for 'some three months', vehemently denied that the company had become defunct. As proof he used some circular reasoning